"The government committee was quite partisan. Because there was nobody from the south in it. Nobody from the northeast. There was no Dalit, no Christian, no tribal, no woman," he says. "The government's intention may be to look at the past from a certain perspective. And so, I thought it will be good to have a holistic group looking at the past."

But the past matters, and so does who studies it. "History means what has been. History also means how one talks about what has been. So in talking about what has been, if there is a diversity in perspective, then what is seen becomes fuller, more comprehensive, non-exclusive, non-partisan," says Devy, who is based in Dharwad and has previously won the Sahitya Akademi and Padma Shri awards for his work.

The 600-plus pages cover a range of topics, from prehistoric agriculture and language families to Sufi thought, the freedom struggle and linguistic state formation. Part of the intention was also to "bring prehistory, proto-history and history together". Devy, too, has two essays in the volume: one on the caste system, and another on the flowering of languages and the Bhakti traditions from about the 11th to the 17th century. He sees both subjects as overlooked aspects of Indian history. Why and how did the caste system emerge? This has not been fully explained. Similarly, for the mediaeval efflorescence that produced the likes of Tukaram, Meera and Kabir. "We have still not said precisely why they emerged. Why at that time, these people emerged, these new languages emerged, the new kind of social and metaphysical philosophy emerged. What were the material challenges, material drives for the emergence?"

The Indians: Histories of a Civilization deliberately uses history in the plural in the title. According to Devy, Indian history doesn't cohere to neat compartments or periods. "In European history, certain movements and certain shifts and changes happen almost all at one time. When we talk about the move from traditional Christianity to Protestantism, then what happens in Germany, England, Spain, Portugal and France, it's almost all at the same time," he says. In India, timelines are not clearly linear. "What change occurs in Kerala in the 12th century may occur in another state like Orissa in the 15th century or yet another state like Sikkim in another century." Which is why it doesn't make sense to speak of 'modernity', for instance, as something that happens across India at the same time.

But despite this geographic, historic, linguistic, ethnic and religious diversity, Devy sees the subcontinent as a unified civilisation. "Civilisations are about intangibles, histories are about material cultures," he says. Here he refers to the famous concept of the "clash of civilisations" popularised by the American political scientist Samuel P. Huntington and frames India in opposition to that. "I realised that we are more inclined towards collaborations, rather than clashes," he says. "And this is the foundational value of our people. There have been clashes, but by and large we have assimilated, we have accepted, we have got into conversations.... We have given birth to many languages, many religions, many kinds of cultural traits. But those new religions, new languages, new cultural traits have not been aggressive in nature, they have been pacifist."

Devy's next project will focus on Asia and will likely involve hundreds of scholars from across countries. "From Turkey to Japan, we need to relook at who these people are, what philosophies they developed, their attitude to language, materials, humans. What is the texture of civilisation in Asia?" he says. ■

Bhavya Dore



ON BEING INDIAN
The Organic Intellectual, Mystical Poetry, and Lineages of Indian Rationalism
by Amit Chaudhuri
WESTLAND
₹399; 88 pages

Saket Gokhale, currently a Trinamool spokesperson and Rajya Sabha MP, as an example of the latter. Chaudhuri writes: "...I call Saket Gokhale an organic intellectual because he seems to come from one of the many hidden lineages that form the true mainstream of any country (rather than an elite conception of a mainstream, which works out of power centres)."

The more interesting strand in the book highlights the complementary relationship between rationality and religion, which are usually pitted as polar opposites. Chaudhuri evokes several examples from the Bhakti movement and his proposition is certainly thought-provoking, if not conclusive.

The book deals with the question of what it means to be Indian, especially an intellectual, in the current milieu

The text of this book entered public life as a "talk delivered semi-extempore from notes" on March 4, 2020, at Delhi's Jamia Millia Islamia University. It was then published in the journal *Social Research: An International Quarterly* in 2021, before making it to book form. While the text must have been revised for publication, it retains the cadence of the spoken word. It's part of the Literary Activism series, a collaboration between Westland, the publisher, and Ashoka University's Centre for the Creative and the Critical. Chaudhuri is also the series editor. So far, two books in the series have been published, the other being Arvind Krishna Mehrotra's *Book of Rahim & Other Poems*. With these, the bar has been set high, and one hopes the series retains its momentum—even if that means swimming against the tide. ■

Amit Dixit